> and seized hold of the Envoy's stirrup-leather and then his hand, which he put to his forehead and lips as a sign of submission. Sir William instantly dismounted and said to the Ameer, 'You are welcome, you are welcome'; and then led him through the Residency garden to his own room. Dost Mohammad, on entering, prostrated himself in Oriental fashion, and taking off his turban, touched the floor with his forehead. On rising he delivered up his sword in token of surrender, saying 'he had no more use for it.' The Envoy immediately returned him the sword, assured the Ameer of every consideration being shown to him, notwithstanding he had so long opposed the British Government. To which the Ameer replied that 'it was his destiny, and he could not oppose it.'

Dost Mohammad was 'a robust, powerful man, with a sharp acquiline nose, highly arched eyebrows' and an untrimmed beard and moustache. 'He . . . told us that previous to the action of Purwan Durrah, he had made up his mind to surrender, and his temporary success in that affair did not in the least alter his determination . . .' Lawrence added, 'Tents were pitched for the Ameer's reception, who was put under my immediate care, and a most anxious duty it was. I scarcely closed my eyes during the two nights he remained under my charge, every now and then getting up to look into the tent to see he was still there; it all seemed so much like a dream that *at last* we should have the Dost safe in our hands, that I could scarcely credit it except by frequent visits to his tent.'[99]

If there was surprise on the British side at the arrival of the Amir, where it was presumed that he had not realised how close to victory he had come, from his own point of view Dost Mohammad was following normal Turko-Persian protocol by his surrender. It was not uncommon for defeated rulers of states to surrender to victorious and growing regional powers in the hope of becoming feudatories. The Durranis and Hotaki Ghilzais had both risen to power as Safavid governors in the late seventeenth century, and the Durrani Empire as it was expanding had often reappointed local rulers as their governors. The system allowed for continuity and stability, and, for the defeated rulers, preservation of life and the possibility of a return to power if circumstances changed.

As Mohammad Husain Herati put it: 'When the English army advanced, like ocean waves one after the other, they had it proclaimed that whoever captured and delivered to them Dost Muhammad Khan would receive a reward of two lakh rupees. The Amir thought: "In this country where people murder each other for one rupee, or five people for five rupees, what chance do I stand of not being betrayed, with such a price on my head?"' By riding into Kabul and surrendering to Macnaghten on his own terms, the